do. Their aged do not starve. Their children are basically healthy. By and large, the people are well clothed'. Would it be better to be born Indian or Chinese, Seth asks himself? If he were among the lucky two-thirds on top of Indian society, he would choose India, 'But if I were born to the inhuman, dehumanising misery in which the poorest third of our [Indian] people live, to the squalor and despair and debility that is their life, my answer would not be the same.'[38] India has its assets – given the climate, Indians need less, they have more arable land and sunshine and (potentially) irrigation – and the country is democratic. Yet, it must be granted that the average Chinese is better off.[39]

What, then, of mutual feeling between the two countries? Seth concludes his book rather gloomily. Ignorance and lack of a shared history typify their relationship: 'friendship rests on understanding; and the two countries, despite their contiguity, have had almost no contact in the course of history . . . the heartlands of the two great culture zones have been almost untouched by each other . . . Unfortunately, I think this will continue . . . The fact that they are both part of the same landmass means nothing. There is no such thing as an Asian ethos or mode of thinking . . . The best that can be hoped for . . . is a respectful patience on either side'.[40]

'Finding India in China'

Two decades later, the Indian scholar Anurag Vishwanath travelled to the remotest corners of China as part of her doctoral research on Chinese reforms and poverty alleviation. Based on fifteen years of travels, she penned an engaging book of encounters that she intriguingly titled *Finding India in China: Travels to the Lesser Known*.[41] In fact, though there are moments in China that evoke a memory of India, the book reveals the opposite: China and India seem economically, socially, and culturally miles apart. Mostly the book is about China and the matter-of-fact interactions she has with Chinese people in remote parts of the country. Yet here and there